

ANI

ment. "The people have taken part in elections with enthusiasm with the hope that there will be improvement in their lives," he said, after visiting the Sher-e-Kashmir Institute of Medical Sciences in Srinagar where the injured were being treated. "We will not step back from that mission. We will not allow the development here to be stopped. If there are shortcomings in the security grid, we will remove them. I spoke to the DGP and we would advise all big projects not to take security issues lightly." Meanwhile, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha has directed authorities to secure vital infrastructure projects across J&K. He emphasised putting in place a multi-pronged, foolproof mechanism for coordination with project implementing agencies to prevent security breaches.

Initial reports suggest that The Resistance Front (TRF), an offshoot of the banned Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT), has claimed responsibility for the attack. The group has been trying to mask its identity to evade scrutiny amid growing global pressure on Pakistan.

According to officials, militancy has significantly gone down in the state over the past five years. With an elected government taking over after a six-year gap, this attack is seen as an attempt to derail peace efforts while setting a precedent for targeting civil infrastructure. Meanwhile, on October 22, J&K Police's Counter Intelligence Kashmir said that it had busted a militant recruitment module with the detention of eight youths linked to the newly formed Tehreek Labaik Ya Muslim, another LeT offshoot.

The 6.4 km Z-Morh tunnel, named for its Z-shaped stretch, is being constructed by the Uttar Pradesh-based APCO Infratech and is set to become operational soon. It is part of the larger Zoji La tunnel initiative, designed to provide faster road access for troops along the Line of Control with Pakistan and the LAC with China.

In the wake of clashes with China and its subsequent incursions into Indian territory along the LAC in Ladakh in 2020, as well as the massive infrastructure buildup, India has intensified efforts by launching key initiatives to enhance its defence and military operations in the border region. Among these initiatives is the year-round accessibility to the cold desert through the construction of tunnels in rugged mountains.

The attack has triggered fear among the migrant workers, with many planning to leave much ahead of winter. The workers arrive in spring and return to their homes before winter, as construction work normally remains suspended for six months due to cold weather. "I am collecting my pending dues to return home as quickly as possible," says Master Ashraf from Bihar, who has worked as a mason in the Valley for decades. "My family calls me to come back after hearing the news."

Meanwhile, Nadigam village in Budgam can't stop mourning its beloved son. The seven deceased included Dr Shahnawaz Ahmed Dar of the village, and people from distant places thronged his home to attend his last rites. "Our village has lost its light," says Ghulam Ahmad, who struggles to understand why innocent workers were killed. "He was our only support in testing times. And what was the crime of the workers who had come from far-off places to earn for their families? It is plain terror."

A police official says reports from survivors suggest the terrorists wanted to inflict maximum damage. This has prompted the National Investigation Agency to join the probe. Union home minister Amit Shah has vowed to avenge the victims saying, "Those involved in this heinous act will not be spared and will face the harshest response." The bloodshed serves as a stark reminder that the struggle for peace in Kashmir continues. ■

THE TROUBLED TUNNEL

- **The 6.4 km Z-Morh tunnel will provide faster and all-weather access for troops along the LoC and LAC**
- **The terror attack at the construction site killed six workers and a doctor, and injured several others**
- **With an elected government, the attack is seen as an attempt to derail peace efforts while setting a precedent of targeting civil infra**



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OMAR ABDULLAH
Chief Minister, Jammu & Kashmir